

WAKE-UP C

■ By Prabhu Chawla

Out of sight, out of mind. Somehow, it doesn't apply to the strange dynamics of Indian politics. Come to think of this 83-year old former prime minister. He is hardly seen. He is seldom heard. And he has already taken voluntary retirement from politics in a country that associates biological antiquity with sagely wisdom. Still, the absence of this man continues to be the overwhelming presence in popular mind. What is more, he is the favourite of the young voters too. Atal Bihari Vajpayee is the ideal prime minister of India. Then, what about the incumbent minister? Gentle. Moderate. Professorial. Dutiful. Clean. Good qualities but not good enough to beat his predecessor in the popularity contest. Forty-four months in office and Manmohan Singh has not yet won the heart of India. He may take solace from the fact that even his political boss, one of the most powerful women in the world, can't beat this old man whom India never gets tired of indulging in its imagination. Sonia Gandhi, more visible now but still inaccessible, is far behind Vajpayee. The INDIA TODAY Mood of the Nation poll sends a wake-up call to the stagnant leadership of the ruling coalition and brings some cheers to the Indian right, which at last shows sign of recovery from the post-2004 defeatism.

Suddenly, India shows impa-

tience—though nothing like the other big democracy—and the first stirrings of change can't be missed in the arena. Leaders have been asked to lead, to step out of their cozy certainties. Low-risk politics, it seems, pays little dividends. The shine on NDA, or that smile on the face of the long distance *yatri* of the Indian right, didn't happen accidentally. With the general elections just 15 months away, leaders who have struggled and succeeded in reducing the distance between the electorate and themselves are back in the game. If L.K Advani has doubled his popularity rating in a span of 12 months, it is because he has changed, in style if not in substance. Accessible and visible, NDA's prime ministerial candidate is seen as a leader who leads from the vanguard. His brand name recognition too has gone up. In our 2004 poll, only 33 per cent recognised his name as the leader of the Opposition. Today about 50 per cent know who he is.

After all, history tells us, India elects a leader, not a party. Our opinion poll too vindicates this. When Indira Gandhi was in the battlefield—or in South Block—she was the agenda as well as the slogan. The same could be said about Rajiv Gandhi too. Outside the Congress, V.P. Singh and Vajpayee exemplified the politics of personality. Prime ministers—barring the accidental ones like Charan Singh, Chandra Shekhar, H.D. Deve Gowda and Inder Kumar Gujral—were the prime

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